

11 July 2023

The Australian Government Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, Senator the Hon. Murray Watt, and state and territory ministers and senior officials responsible for forestry met virtually today.

This is the first meeting of Forestry Ministers since September 2021.

The meeting acknowledged the importance of the contribution of the sector across our economy and the significance of its ability to deliver high order environmental outcomes.

Participants discussed the strength of forest industries around Australia, issues facing the sector and work underway in each jurisdiction to grow its critical contribution to meeting national needs.

Minister Watt advised the meeting that he has established a Strategic Forest and Renewable Materials Partnership to provide a forum for industry, unions and the Australian Government to consult, exchange advice and information, and promote cooperation within the forest and wood products industries.

The Partnership is being charged with the development of a long term national plan – the Timber Fibre Strategy – to set an agreed strategic direction for the forest and wood products sectors.

Minister Watt invited the Partnership's co-chairs Michael O'Connor and Diana Gibbs (represented by Joel Fitzgibbon), to provide an overview of the Partnership's work outline.

Minister Watt welcomed the commitments from states and territories to contribute to its development.

The meeting agreed their future workplan will focus on the agreed priorities of:

- increasing resource security and domestic supply volumes
- expanding the production of timber and wood products
- expanding forestry's contribution to climate change mitigation
- expanding timber industry workforce opportunities and capacity
- continued sustainable management of forests.

The Ministers tasked officials to draft a workplan for their future consideration and to establish an officials meeting to support Forestry Ministers.

Ministers agreed to meet again in October 2023, including to review the draft workplan.

Ministerial attendees:

- Australian Government (Chair): Senator the Hon Murray Watt, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry and Minister for Emergency Management
- Australian Capital Territory: Mick Gentleman, MLA, Minister for Planning and Land Management

- New South Wales: the Hon Tara Moriarty MLC, Minister for Agriculture, Minister for Regional New South Wales and Minister for Western New South Wales
- Northern Territory: the Hon Paul Kirby MLA, Minister for Agribusiness and Fisheries
- Queensland: the Hon Mark Furner MP, Minister for Agriculture Industry Development and Fisheries, and Minister for Rural Communities
- South Australia: the Hon Clare Scriven MLC, Minister for Forest Industries, Minister for Primary Industries and Regional Development
- Tasmania: the Hon Felix Ellis MP, Minister for Resources and Minister for Police, Fire and Emergency Management; Minister for Skills, Training and Workforce Growth
- Victoria: the Hon Gayle Tierney MLC, Minister for Agriculture, Minister for Training and Skills, Minister for Higher Education
- Western Australia: the Hon Jackie Jarvis MLC, Minister for Agriculture and Food, Forestry, Small Business

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/forestry-ministers-july-23>